Chapter 15

Dealing with Jailhouse Shocks: Relentless Efforts at Minimizing Them

DURING KIRAN'S TERM OF OFFICE, TIHAR, INDIA'S MAXIMUM-SECURITY prison, was a sprawling complex covering over 180 acres. The complex contained four independent jails. The entire area was encompassed by high imposing walls, with the armed constabulary of the Tamil Nadu Police Force patrolling the perimeter. Grim sentinels perched in high sentry boxes had ominous-looking automatic weapons trained at entry and exit points. Massive iron gates with iron bars and huge padlocks appeared as seals to the fates of the over 9500 humans enclosed within. It was truly a sight to fill the mind with trepidation and fear; an awesome sight to compel the entrant to abandon all hope, and push him or her to despair.

Inside the prison walls, however, the atmosphere belied all such fears. Strains of religious hymns and songs greeted you as you entered the prisoners' barracks. All around were groups of persons sitting and studying in regular classes. Every barrack had its own library where you could see the inmates engrossed in reading newspapers, magazines and books. Everyone, yes everyone, was occupied with something or the other, be it studying, or exercising, or practising yoga, or repairing television sets, or knitting, or sewing or performing a score of other activities. The inmates did not appear tense or worked up but more like any other member of society, busy with his or her daily work-a-day life. They certainly had complaints and frustrations in plenty about the quantity of time spent as under-trails, but almost none of them about the quality of the time they were spending there.

Yet, Tihar had earlier built up a most unenviable track record: of corruption in the administration; of the brutality of a concentration camp; of a well-functioning prisoner mafia; of unethical practices by the medical staff; of free availability of narcotic drugs; of sex abuse by prisoners and staff alike; of extortion, blackmail and unhygienic conditions – of anything and everything that it takes to make a hellhole on earth.

The deputy superintendent of Jail 4, Sunil Gupta, who had worked in Tihar Jail for over twelve years, spoke quite candidly about its past:

> The atmosphere here bred criminality. Prisoners with lesser or petty crimes were indoctrinated by the more hardened ones. The rank and file of a number of gangs were recruited here. As a matter of fact, the infamous Tyagi and Manjit gangs (gang leaders who had unleashed a reign of terror in the Meerut, Ghaziabad and Bulandshahar districts of Uttar Pradesh and who were involved in innumerable cases of extortion, blackmail, ransom kidnappings and murder) were formed here itself. There were no attempts made to stop this because of fear of these criminals and more so because of a directionless leadership. The jail was run more by the diktat of the hardened criminals rather than by us.